first introduced to Mr Eriksson when we joined up ahead of his first game in charge, an exhibition against Spain, at Villa Park. When we arrived at the team hotel, I got a message that he wanted to see me.

It was just a chance to say hello, and to let me know a little about how he planned to approach the job. Sven had been going round the country watching dozens of games. There'd been so much talk about him ahead of that first match in charge. Even a hoax phone call, put in to him by a radio DJ pretending to be Kevin Keegan, went out over the air in Manchester. One of the questions had been about me: would he keep me as captain? And Sven had said yes. Obviously, I hadn't taken that at face value and I'd been worrying—really worrying—for the week leading up to our first get-together. Lucky for me, I heard what I was desperate to hear almost at once:

'You'll be staying as captain. I think you'll make a great England captain. You're a good enough player and a player others can lookup to. Anybody who doubts that, it's your job to prove them wrong.'

What he told me, and told the rest of the team, was pretty simple. Sven wanted England to play good, attractive soccer. But he also wanted us to play effective soccer. The training was relaxed, especially because Steve McClaren, Peter Taylor and Sammy Lee were all part of the coaching staff at first. There was nothing revolutionary going on: Sven was calm, was prepared to let other people get on with what he wanted them to do and just got involved himself when he needed to make his point. And when he did that, every player listened. Never mind his reputation, Sven had a real presence that commanded respect and attention. The players knew straight away that England had put the right man in charge. The rules were clear and simple and you didn't cross them. We were treated like men, given respect and, at the same time, expected to take responsibility for ourselves. I believe it's an approach every England player has responded to.

Despite it being only an exhibition, there was a definite buzz in the air at Villa Park– this was the start of something new, wasn't it?—and we beat Spain 3–0. We all knew that the first real test would be the next World Cup qualifier. After losing to Germany and then drawing in Helsinki, the game against Finland at Anfield was pretty much win or bust. If we didn't take the three points for the win, we were going to have a real problem getting to the play-offs, never mind qualifying automatically by topping the group. This was a genuinely competitive game and we needed to come up with a result as a team. Personally, as the new England captain, I felt I needed to come up with something too.